

To backup or not to backup: SQL Server's master, msdb and model"

Role and Importance of System Databases (master / msdb / model)

- The main system databases in a SQL Server instance are **master**, **msdb**, **model**, and **tempdb** (plus others such as Resource).
- These system databases do *not* store the business data (user databases), but store the critical metadata, configuration, scheduling and template data which govern how SQL Server works and how user database's function.

Backup-Need Evaluation: For Each System Database

Model Database

- Purpose: acts as a **template**. When you create a new database, SQL Server copies the model database structure (and any objects in it) into the new one.
- Backup necessity: **Generally, no** — if you're only using model as a default template structure, and you keep its definition (objects/settings) as code (e.g. in version control), backup adds limited value.
- When it makes sense: If you have inserted a substantial amount of data or customized objects inside model (rare but sometimes done), then backing up may become relevant.

Msdb Database

- What it stores: all scheduling/configuration for SQL Server Agent (jobs, schedules, alerts), backup/restore history (information SSMS uses when restoring), maintenance plan definitions — basically everything tied to automation, maintenance, and job scheduling.
- Need to back up: **Yes**, if you use SQL Agent jobs or rely on backup/restore history, maintenance plans, or SSMS UI restore functionality.
- Frequency and retention: Recommended to back up **frequently**, ideally along with your regular database backups — e.g. if you run transaction-log backups every 15 min, then msdb backup every 15 min (or soon after) is suggested. For retention, you may keep only minimal copies (e.g. last 1–2) because msdb tends to be small.

Master Database

- What it stores: system-level metadata — logins, security settings, metadata of all databases (names, file locations), server configuration, instance-wide settings, etc. Without master, SQL Server cannot start.
- Need to back up: **Yes**, but with important caveats. Back up especially after any server-level configuration change, or after adding/removing databases, changing logins or roles, altering server settings.
- Complexity & Restoration caveats:
 - The master DB backup is **strongly version- and configuration-dependent** — version of SQL Server, service pack level, OS, instance name, external configuration all matter. Restoring master on a different environment (e.g. different host, OS, edition) might cause issues.

- Restoration requires starting SQL Server in **single-user mode**.
- Because of these constraints, in some cases (clean OS/server or major drift) it may be simpler to rebuild system databases, then re-create server configuration rather than trust master-DB restore.
- Backup frequency & retention: Preferably after configuration changes; if changes are rare (e.g. once a year), backing up monthly may suffice. Retain only recent 1–2 backups, because rolling back far in time rarely makes sense.

What Happens If You Don't Back Up System Databases

- Without msdb backup — loss of all SQL Agent jobs, schedules, alerts, maintenance plans, backup-restore history; reverting to manual recreation after a failure.
- Without master backup — if master DB corrupts or is lost, SQL Server may not start; recovery may require rebuilding system databases and manually recreating all logins, server settings, database mappings — a time-consuming and error-prone process.
- Without model backup (if model was customized) — new databases created after model loss will not have your custom defaults/templates; could lead to inconsistency and extra manual work.

Recommended Best-Practice Approach

Based on the article + best practices:

- Always **include msdb** in your regular backup routine if you rely on jobs, maintenance plans, or restore history.
- Back up **master** after any server-level change (new login, config change, adding/removing DB, etc.).
- For **model**, maintain its structure in version control (as DDL scripts) rather than backing up regularly (unless you've modified it substantially).
- Keep a minimal retention policy for system database backups (e.g. store last 1–2 backups); storing many old versions rarely provides benefit.
- Ensure restore procedures are documented and tested (especially for master and msdb), including steps to run in single-user mode, and to rebuild system DBs if needed.

Source: https://sqlbak.com/blog/to-backup-or-not-to-backup-sql-servers-master-msdb-and-model/?utm_campaign=master_msdb_model_guide

Author: [Ivan Gusev](#)